a raja could've owned another raja. Unlike the upper-caste response, the Dom response is best understood in the context of a marginalized caste seeking a measure of dignity by association and inference. In a caste order based on purity and pollution, the Doms and their work rank near the very bottom. No one else aspires to it. Yet, like the Mallahs, these Doms of Varanasi claim exclusive rights to conduct cremations on the two ghats. No one from outside their clan—even if they work on cremation ghats elsewhere—is permitted to work here.

The current Dom Raja's name is Jagdish Chaudhary. All Doms of Varanasi, as many as 5000, are his relatives and have the same surname (prevalent in both 'high' and 'low' castes). He is the sole employer of all Dom workers on the cremation ghats, a minority of all Doms. A compulsive paan chewer, the Dom Raja helps resolve disputes and offers financial aid for weddings and health emergencies to clan members.

While a Dom sets up the pyre, four kinsmen of the deceased bring in the corpse on a bamboo bier. They go down to the river, wade into it, and lower the bier to dunk the body in the 'sacred' waters of the Ganga. The Mahabharata says, 'If only a bone of a person shall touch the water of the Ganga, that person shall dwell, honoured, in heaven.'[46] Thus 'purified', they remove the orange shroud, transfer the wet body wrapped in plain whites on to the pyre and pay their final respects (women traditionally do so at home and do not attend funerals, but this is changing in urban India). If the deceased lived a healthy life well past eighty, there may even be muted celebration of his good fortune of a long life, admixed with quiet sorrow. The priest begins the rituals and the chanting—part of the *antim sanskaar*, or last rites, which vary as per the deceased's region, caste and other social factors. To attain moksha at Manikarnika, however, every pyre must be lit by the 'sacred flame' kept by the Dom Raja, for which he charges a *kar* ('tax') of Rs 500. This paves the way for Shiva to whisper the taraka mantra in the deceased's ears. Thus, in the end, even the 'purest' Brahmin requires the 'untouchable' Dom for the liberation of his soul.

The chief mourner, usually the closest male kin, sprinkles ghee on the pyre, and is then handed a straw torch to set it alight—an intensely emotional moment for the kinsmen. The first fire, *mukhagni*, is ritually lit at the mouth. A Dom funerary worker might sprinkle more ghee and insert